



got married within three weeks of having met each other, she did not get time to finish her PhD, instead she received her master's of Philosophy in English.

They have two sons. The elder son is an entrepreneur, making a go of his startup. The younger son is a venture capitalist; he was recently featured in the '40 Under 40' list. Vinod is a happy grandfather with one granddaughter and one grandson.

Along with living a happy family life, Vinod continues nurturing his entrepreneurial aspirations. He left Intel in 1995 and joined the microprocessor startup Nexgen as COO. Vinod's insight helped Nexgen in successful acquisition of the company by Advanced Micro Devices (AMD), an emerging leader in the semiconductor computing industry.

Gradually, his interest shifted beyond microprocessors. After spending one year in AMD, he started the communications processors startup Silicon Spice and worked as its CEO and President. His leadership helped develop the first multichannel Voice over IP (Internet protocol) chip, part of an eco-system that enables applications like WhatsApp used by billions around the world to make phone calls. In 2000, Vinod sold Silicon Spice to Broadcom for \$1.2 billion in an all-stock deal.



Vinod Dham with family

Giving back to India

"After making two successful attempts as an entrepreneur, first at NexGen and then at Silicon Spice, I was constantly thinking of the ways I could help India create similar successes for talented Indian engineers, like Silicon Valley did for me. This led to my maiden attempt at setting up NewPath Ventures, a cross-border incubator for a handful of high tech entrepreneurs, where we primarily did R&D in India and business, sales, and marketing from the USA," tells Vinod.

Subsequently, Vinod became one among a handful of early pioneers who set up early-stage venture capital funds on the ground in India, around 2005-06, which laid the foundation of a silicon valley style startup eco-system, catapulting

India to the third largest startup system in the world, with scores of unicorns in the pipeline. He informs, "I founded Indo-US Ventures, an early-stage VC fund. We raised close to \$200 million and invested in a score of companies and were fortunate to have some of the successful Indian startups in our portfolio," Vinod says while discussing his India-centric initiatives.

He believes that integrity and fire in the belly are the most important criteria for selecting a budding entrepreneur for providing venture capital. In spite of having an excellent product idea, and a huge market opportunity, a startup may not succeed in a big way without a founder who has fire in the belly to succeed and has high integrity. Even if the original idea doesn't work, a driven founder will figure out a way to pivot and make success out of it.

Vinod and his wife Sadhana are donors to many charities in the US and India. He has been a trustee of the American India Foundation since 2001. In 2006, Vinod was appointed Chair of the Digital Equalizer (DE) Program with a mission to provide underprivileged children in India with the opportunity to enhance their learning through the use of digital technology in a scalable and sustainable manner. As Chair of the DE Program, he led the program's strategic direction and growth.

Vinod would like to dedicate the next five years of his professional life to laying the foundation for the Indian semiconductor mission. "It is going to be challenging for India to enter the field of semiconductors after 50 years since the chip industry started taking off. One of our biggest challenges is going to be skilling domestic talent for this sector," he opines. **EFY**

Some of Vinod Dham's favourites:

- **Favourite show.** Indian Idol. His wife and he pre-record it and watch it every week. They find it heartening to see the talented kids sing so beautifully. Indian music is a big unifier for us Indians, according to them.
- **Favourite music.** Sufi music that connects him with the eternal. He finds very good Sufi songs on Coke Studio.
- **Favourite food.** Homecooked *rajma-chawal*, the typical Punjabi food, which his mom used to cook on Tuesdays.
- **Favourite film.** Three Days of the Condor, a 1975 American political thriller film with Robert Redford as the lead actor. It shows that governments may sacrifice a few of their own for a larger purpose of helping their nation.
- **Favourite pastime.** Reading about the universe, where we came from, and how it all started.
- **Favourite book.** The Tao of Physics: An Exploration of the Parallels Between Modern Physics and Eastern Mysticism, a 1975 book by physicist Fritjof Capra.